

Nobel Prize Acceptance Speech

Assigned by: Mr. A

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Summary

In his Nobel Peace Prize acceptance speech, Holocaust survivor Elie Wiesel explained what fueled his work. He began by asking whether he had the right to speak for all those who perished. He concluded that he didn't but swore that he felt their presence, especially that of his parents and younger sister. Wiesel clearly remembered the horror and anguish of the ghettos and the deportation of Jews via cattle cars. He remembered that as a child he asked his father how this could happen in the twentieth century. Wiesel informed the audience that he continued to speak to his younger self, asking him to keep these memories alive so that no one ever forgets. Wiesel dedicated his life to speaking out against injustice, and implored people to intervene when others are persecuted on the basis of their race, religion, or political views.

Read

- 1 And it is with a profound sense of **humility** that I accept the honor -the highest there is - that you have chosen to bestow upon me. I know your choice transcends my person.
- 2 Do I have the right to represent the **multitudes** who have perished? Do I have the right to accept this great honor on their behalf? I do not. No one may speak for the dead, no one may interpret their mutilated dreams and visions. And yet, I sense their presence. I always do -and at this moment more than ever. The presence of my parents, that of my little sister. The presence of my teachers, my friends, my companions....
- 3 This honor belongs to all the survivors and their children and, through us to the Jewish people with whose destiny I have always identified.
- 4 I remember: it happened yesterday, or eternities ago. A young Jewish boy discovered

the Kingdom of Night. I remember his bewilderment, I remember his anguish. It all happened so fast. The ghetto. The **deportation**. The sealed cattle car. The fiery altar upon which the history of our people and the future of mankind were meant to be sacrificed.

- 5 I remember he asked his father: "Can this be true? This is the twentieth century, not the Middle Ages. Who would allow such crimes to be committed? How could the world remain silent?"
- 6 And now the boy is turning to me. "Tell me," he asks, "what have you done with my future, what have you done with your life?"
- 7 And I tell him that I have tried. That I have tried to keep memory alive, that I have tried to fight those who would forget. Because if we forget, we are guilty, we are accomplices.
- 8 And then I explain to him how **naïve** we were, that the world did know and remained silent. And that is why I swore never to be silent whenever wherever human beings endure suffering and humiliation. We must take sides. Neutrality helps the oppressor, never the victim. Silence encourages the tormentor, never the tormented. Sometimes we must interfere. When human lives are endangered, when human dignity is in jeopardy, national borders and sensitivities become irrelevant. Wherever men and women are persecuted because of their race, religion, or political views, that place must -at that moment -become the center of the universe.
- 9 Human rights are being **violated** on every continent. More people are oppressed than free. How can one not be sensitive to their plight? Human suffering anywhere concerns men and women everywhere...
- 10 There is so much to be done, there is so much that can be done. One person -a Raoul Wallenberg, an Albert Schweitzer, Martin Luther King, Jr. -one person of integrity, can make a difference, a difference of life and death.
- 11 As long as one dissident is in prison, our freedom will not be true. As long as one child

is hungry, our life will be filled with anguish and shame. What all these victims need above all is to know that they are not alone; that we are not forgetting them, that when their voices are stifled we shall lend them ours, that while their freedom depends on ours, the quality of our freedom depends on theirs.

- 12 This is what I say to the young Jewish boy wondering what I have done with his years. It is in his name that I speak to you and that I express to you my deepest gratitude as one who has emerged from the Kingdom of Night. We know that every moment is a moment of grace, every hour an offering; not to share them would mean to betray them.
- 13 Our lives no longer belong to us alone; they belong to all those who need us desperately.

Annotations
